

Ontology to epistemology to methodology — the logic chain your Chapter 3 must show

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A research paradigm is the set of beliefs about reality and knowledge that underpins a study and determines its methods. It runs as a chain: ontology (what reality is) shapes epistemology (how we can know it), which shapes methodology (how we investigate) and finally methods (the specific techniques). Coherence down this chain is what examiners look for; a mismatch — e.g. an interpretivist stance with a hypothesis-testing design — is a common flag (Crotty, 1998).

QUANTITATIVE / POSITIVIST

Ontology: one objective reality. Epistemology: knowledge is uncovered; there is one true explanation. Methodology: positivist, objectivist, nomothetic. Reasoning: deductive (theory to data). Designs: experimental, survey, RCT.

QUALITATIVE / INTERPRETIVIST

Ontology: multiple socially-constructed realities. Epistemology: meaning is culturally defined. Methodology: interpretivist, hermeneutic. Reasoning: inductive (data to theory). Designs: case study, ethnography, action research.

Pragmatism — the third way. Pragmatists reject the either/or: the research question drives the method, and mixing quantitative and qualitative is legitimate when it answers the question better. Most mixed-methods MBA dissertations sit here — but must still justify how the strands integrate.

Level	Quantitative stance	Qualitative stance
Ontology	One objective reality	Multiple realities
Epistemology	One true explanation to uncover	Meaning is culturally defined
Methodology	Positivist, objectivist, nomothetic	Hermeneutic, interpretivist
Reasoning	Deductive	Inductive
Design	Experimental, survey, RCT	Case study, ethnography, action research

DECIDE FIRST

Fix your ontology and epistemology before choosing methods. The stance is the foundation; the method is the consequence, not the other way round.

READ DOWN A COLUMN

Keep every choice in one column consistent. Justify your paradigm explicitly in Chapter 3 — don't leave it implicit.

COHERENCE IS GRADED

The most common methodology flag is incoherence: a stance and a design that contradict each other. Consistency signals methodological control.

Common pitfalls. (1) Skipping the paradigm and jumping straight to methods. (2) Claiming positivism while collecting rich interpretive interview data. (3) Confusing methodology (the strategy) with methods (the techniques). (4) Naming a paradigm but never justifying why it fits the question.

REFERENCES

Crotty, M. (1998) *The Foundations of Social Research*. London: SAGE. · Saunders, M., Lewis, P. and Thornhill, A. (2019) *Research Methods for Business Students*. 8th edn. Harlow: Pearson. · Guba, E.G. and Lincoln, Y.S. (1994) 'Competing paradigms in qualitative research', in Denzin, N.K. and Lincoln, Y.S. (eds.) *Handbook of Qualitative Research*. Thousand Oaks: SAGE.